The 6:15

THURSDAY · OCTOBER 29, 2026 NO. 32

THE BOARD

CALENDAR — NEXT 10 DAYS

Thu 10/29 (today)	Q3 GDP advance estimate (BEA) & weekly jobless claims, 8:30a ET — neither out as of press time; GDP consensus ~3.2% annualized (FXStreet) vs. Q2's final 2.2%. AMZN reports Q3 after the 4p ET close, call at 5p.
Fri 10/31	Knicks at 76ers, 7:30p ET.
Sat 10/31	Northwestern at Oregon, Eugene — first-ever meeting; kickoff by 8p ET, network TBD. OPEC+ meets; Oct. 4 decision held Nov. output flat at 31.01M bpd, no change signaled for this round.
Tue 11/3	Midterm elections — House and Senate majorities both in play.
[NEW]	Brewers beat Rays 4-1 in Game 5 Wed. night, winning the World Series — first title in franchise history.

No confirmed frontier AI release or major rocket launch surfaced this run. Microsoft/Alphabet Q3 reports (below) landed Wed. after close, ahead of Amazon tonight.

METRICS · ~6:15A ET UNLESS NOTED

Brent / WTI	$114.01 (-1.14%) / $101.31 (-1.43%) — oilprice.com, ~11-min delay. Spread ~$12.70.
Treasury 2Y/10Y/30Y	4.70% / 5.05% / 5.36% **(mixed timestamps)**
DXY	102.23 (+0.04%) — Yahoo Finance, 6:14a ET.
S&P / Nasdaq-100 futures	7,766.00 (-0.22%) / 29,687.25 (-0.97%) — 6:14a ET.
VIX	~17.0 **(source internally inconsistent this run)**
Gold	$4,032.10 (-0.85%) — Kitco, 6:22a ET.

Wed. 10/28 close	Dow 52,475.10 (+0.19%); S&P 500 7,743.98 (+0.28%, a record close, exact level varies $7,738-$7,744 by source); Nasdaq Comp. 26,549.85 (+0.27%) [NEW].
Europe / Asia	FTSE 100 10,740.66 (+0.43%), 10:09a GMT, intraday; Nikkei 225 ~64,659 (+1.10%), close date on source page unclear **(flag)**.
Retail gas (AAA natl.)	$4.2258/gal (10/29), down from Tue.'s $4.2661 — second straight decline on record [DEVELOPING].

Oil, rates and equities all moved against Monday's levels; see Lead. 2Y yield is an intraday Oct. 29 read (tradingeconomics.com); 10Y/30Y are Wed. 10/28 official closes (Yahoo) — not contemporaneous, flagged rather than blended.

HORMUZ COUNTERS — STRAITS.LIVE, 29 OCT 1017Z (6:17A ET)

Transits	2 vessels, Oct. 25 (~2% of 85/day baseline) — IMF PortWatch, 4 days stale.
Dark tankers, 24h	46 of 182 screened (25.3%) vs. 7-day avg. of 110.5 dark **[NEW — sharp drop from Tue.'s 70.8%/226 screened]**
War-risk premium	~32.0x pre-crisis — Oct. 7 estimate, 22 days stale; background only.
Indices	Crisis Pressure 88±12 (Extreme, flat 24h); Escalation Forecast 61±11 (High, flat 24h).
Closure status	Day 242, per straits.live's transit framing.

Dark-tanker drop is straits.live's own AIS screen — sensitive to ambient dropout and total traffic volume, not independently corroborated. See Iran & Hormuz for the morning's claims.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	Season over (eliminated Oct. 7).
Knicks	No reported trades or signings in the last 24 hours.
Northwestern	No reported moves.

LEAD

FED & BIG TECH

The Fed holds with a hawkish dissent, Microsoft's discipline beats Alphabet's AI-capex surge, and

Wall Street turns to GDP, claims and Amazon before tonight's close

Wednesday stacked three market-moving events into about four hours, and the pattern that emerged is as important as any single number. The Fed held its target range at 3.75%-4.00% for a third straight meeting, by a 10-2 vote — but the dissents ran hawkish, not dovish: Governor Lisa Cook and Cleveland Fed President Beth Hammack both wanted a quarter-point hike. [fact, NEW] Chair Kevin Warsh told reporters he doesn't "believe in forward guidance, absent exigent circumstances," called the economy strong, and said the committee would consider rate changes at only seven of eight meetings in 2027 and six of eight in 2028 — fewer decision points, not more easing. He denied politics factored into a decision landing six days before the midterms. [fact, NEW] Prediction markets, which had priced an Oct. 28 hold at roughly 83%-85% going in, now put the odds of a quarter-point hike at the Dec. 9 meeting at somewhere between 75% and 85% depending on the venue (DeFi Rate's Kalshi/Polymarket blend vs. a separate Yahoo Finance-sourced figure) — a sizable jump from the low-70s a week earlier. [fact/read, NEW]

Then came the split that mattered more for positioning. Microsoft's fiscal Q1 revenue rose 19% to $92.3 billion, beating the Street's $90.61 billion estimate, with EPS of $4.92 (one tracker shows $4.89 on a constant-currency, OpenAI-adjusted basis — the gap is real and this brief flags it rather than picking one) against a $4.72 estimate. [fact, NEW] Azure grew 48% in constant currency, beating Microsoft's own 44%-45% guidance, while quarterly capital spending of $45.2 billion came in below the company's own "over $50 billion" outlook. [fact, NEW] Alphabet told a different story: revenue

rose 25% to $127.6 billion — its 13th straight quarter of double-digit growth, beating a $123.76 billion estimate — with Cloud revenue more than doubling, up 103% to $30.7 billion, and operating margin at 31.8%. [fact, NEW] But Search revenue growth decelerated to 12% from 17% the prior quarter, and capital expenditure more than doubled to $51.4 billion. [fact, NEW] Microsoft rose roughly 4%-5% after hours; Alphabet, which had closed the regular session up 1.6% at $321.89, fell about 10.5% to roughly $288. [fact, NEW]

Read: the stock reaction split almost exactly along capital-spending discipline, not the headline beat-or-miss. Microsoft spent less than it told investors it would and still posted the faster cloud growth; Alphabet spent more than double the prior year and still saw its core ad-search engine slow down. A revenue beat wasn't enough to protect a stock whose capex trajectory and growth mix both moved the wrong way in the same quarter. That is the question Amazon now has to answer tonight, after the 4p ET close and a 5p call: AWS has posted the industry's highest growth rate most of this year, but Amazon has also been among the most aggressive capital spenders — if its Q3 print reads like Alphabet's (capex up sharply, a core segment decelerating) rather than Microsoft's (spending under its own guide, growth beating it), expect a similarly unforgiving reaction. [read]

The second-order consequence sits one layer down: a Fed that just signaled its own center of gravity is shifting toward a December hike — not away from one — removes the rate-cut cushion that has underwritten a year of aggressive AI infrastructure spending by the hyperscalers. Cheaper financing was always the quiet assumption behind capex guides measured in the hundreds of billions; Wednesday's dissent axis argues that assumption needs re-pricing,

right as Thursday's calendar delivers the GDP advance estimate and jobless claims at 8:30a ET — both still unreleased as this went to press — and Amazon's results test whether Wednesday's capex-discipline verdict was stock-specific or sets the bar for the whole group. [read] Watch: 8:30a for GDP (consensus ~3.2% annualized) and claims (last reading 194,000, a three-month low); the regular session's reaction to Wednesday's dual earnings prints, still working through the complex at the open; and whether Amazon's after-hours move tonight confirms or breaks the Microsoft-vs.-Alphabet split.

POLITICS

Six days from the midterms, Reuters/Ipsos's Oct. 19 poll had Trump's approval at 31% — a record low for either of his terms, with 66% disapproving. Multiple outlets this week cited a newer Reuters/Ipsos figure of 32%, described as tying or holding at that record low; this brief could not independently confirm the newer poll's exact fieldwork dates, so treat it as directionally consistent with, not a confirmed fresh decline from, the Oct. 19 reading. [flag, DEVELOPING] Forecast models and prediction markets continue to diverge: one model gives Democrats a 94.7% chance of winning the House and 62.1% of the Senate, while prediction-market snapshots show House control priced closer to 85% Democratic and the Senate essentially a coin flip (roughly 51¢ Republican vs. 48¢ Democratic in one snapshot). Democrats need a net gain of at least four Senate seats; Michigan, Texas and North Carolina are cited repeatedly as the key battlegrounds, though this brief treats that list as background color rather than a verified ranking. [read] Warsh's on-record denial that Wednesday's hold was politically timed (see Lead) is itself a marker of how closely the Fed and the election are being read together this week.

ECONOMICS

Today's data — not the Fed, which the Lead covers — is what's actually new here, and none of it has printed yet. The BEA's Q3 advance GDP estimate and the Labor Department's weekly jobless-claims report both land at 8:30a ET; as of this writing, bea.gov's release page still shows Q2's third estimate (2.2%, published Sept. 30) as its most recent GDP item, and no October 29 claims figure has surfaced. [fact, flag] Consensus for GDP clusters around 3.2% annualized (FXStreet), against the Atlanta Fed's GDPNow nowcast of 3.6% as of mid-October — a low-confidence model, flagged as such. On claims, last week's report (week ended Oct. 17) showed initial filings falling to 194,000, a three-month low and below the roughly 200,000 expected, with the four-week average at 197,750 — the lowest since 2022 — and continuing claims up 25,000 to 1.728 million. A September PCE price-index date flagged as unconfirmed in the prior issue remains unresolved this run. [continuity, flag]

BUSINESS

Beyond the headline splits in the Lead: Microsoft's commercial remaining performance obligation — contracted future revenue — grew 73% to $677 billion, and Microsoft Cloud revenue overall reached $63.90 billion, up 30%. [fact, NEW] A reported FY2027 full-year capex guide near $175 billion (from pre-earnings previews, not independently confirmed against Wednesday's call) would imply spending accelerates sharply from this quarter's $45.2 billion pace if accurate — this brief flags rather than compounds that read. Separately, Microsoft's move to extend the depreciable life of its data centers and office buildings from 15 to 25 years, effective this fiscal year, mechanically lowers reported depreciation and lifts margins;

compare this quarter's profitability to year-ago figures with that in mind. [flag, continuity] Amazon's Q3 report, due after today's close with a 5p ET call, has no verified consensus in this brief's sourcing this run — tracker figures disagreed by source and fiscal-period convention, so none is printed as a hard number, per the sources-of-record rule on earnings calendars. [flag] AAA's national average gas price fell to $4.2258/gal Thursday from Tuesday's $4.2661 — a second recorded decline, continuing the pattern flagged in the prior issue. [fact, DEVELOPING]

TECHNOLOGY

The capex-versus-growth divide in the Lead is this week's defining hyperscaler story, and Alphabet's numbers carry the clearest warning. Google Cloud's 103% revenue growth leaned partly on TPU systems sales, a mix shift worth tracking since it's a lower-margin, more capital-intensive business than core Search. [read] Search itself — still Alphabet's profit engine — grew 12%, down from 17% last quarter, even as the division absorbing the heaviest new spending (Cloud) scales fastest; that combination is exactly the kind of mix shift a 10%-plus overnight repricing tends to flag. [read] Microsoft's contrasting restraint — capex under its own guide, Azure beating its own guide — reads, for now, as evidence that capital discipline and AI-driven growth aren't mutually exclusive, but it's one data point against Alphabet's one data point, not yet a sector verdict. [read] No frontier model release, major funding round, or orbital launch surfaced as new in this run's research; this brief isn't padding the section with background items (Moonshot AI's pre-IPO round, Bezos's Project Prometheus) already covered in prior issues.

IRAN & HORMUZ

The most-watched Hormuz counter moved sharply overnight: straits.live's dark-tanker screen, which had held near 70%-72% of screened tankers running dark through Monday and Tuesday, read 46 of 182 screened (25.3%) for the 24 hours into this morning — a large drop against a 7-day average of 110.5 dark tankers. [fact, NEW] This brief treats that as a straits.live-methodology artifact until corroborated elsewhere: the screen measures AIS dropout among whatever traffic transits, and IMF PortWatch's own transit count (2 vessels on Oct. 25, against an 85/day pre-crisis baseline) suggests overall volume remains near-zero, meaning a falling dark-tanker percentage could reflect less traffic to screen rather than more vessels broadcasting normally. [read] The composite indices didn't move: Crisis Pressure held at 88 (Extreme) and the Escalation Forecast at 61 (High), both flat for a second straight day.

The overnight claims followed the same pattern this brief has flagged all month: state-media assertions running ahead of independent confirmation, with one partial exception. UKMTO-sourced reports of a vessel fire off Oman's coast appeared via two separate outlets (Anadolu Ajansı, Middle East Eye) early Thursday — both citing the UK maritime agency directly, which this brief treats as more credible than a single state-media claim, though UKMTO's own advisory text wasn't independently retrieved this run. [fact/flag, NEW] Separately and not corroborated: Iran's IRGC claimed three tankers hit mines or exploded on an "unauthorized route" (Press TV, Arab News PK) and claimed capturing a US surveillance drone (WANA News Agency) — both single-sourced to Iranian or Iran-aligned outlets. [fact, NEW, single-sourced] One claim stands out for separate

reasons: a Free Press Kashmir report that Iran said it is "in touch with intermediaries" on a strait-reopening scheme — if accurate, the first sign of renewed movement since Foreign Minister Araghchi's Oct. 18 restatement that Iran's seven-point reopening plan remains on the table, but this brief could verify only the single source and flags it accordingly rather than treating it as confirmed diplomacy. [flag, single-sourced, DEVELOPING] Methodology note, as always: IRGC/state-media claims, UKMTO advisories, PortWatch's lagged AIS transit count and straits.live's dark-tanker screen measure different things over different windows and are never averaged or differenced here.

SPORTS

World Series	Brewers 4, Rays 1 (Game 5, Wed.) — Milwaukee wins its first World Series title in the franchise's 57-year history, 4 games to 1; catcher William Contreras named MVP.
Yankees	Season over; eliminated Oct. 7, swept 3-0 by Tampa Bay in the ALDS.
Knicks	0-3; no game since Sunday's 111-102 home loss to Orlando; next up Friday at Philadelphia, 7:30p ET.
Northwestern	6-1 (3-1 Big Ten); no game since Oct. 24's 42-14 win over Rutgers; travels to Oregon Saturday, first-ever meeting.

Continuity. Geopolitics (Russia-Ukraine) was cut — no dated, verifiable development surfaced this run beyond the single-sourced Oct. 11 energy-truce claim already carried in prior issues. Watch for next issue: today's GDP/claims prints and market reaction; Amazon's Q3 report and after-hours move; whether straits.live's dark-tanker drop holds or reverses; whether UKMTO publishes its own advisory on the Oman-area vessel fire; the Reuters/Ipsos approval figure's actual fieldwork date; and five days to the midterms.

Unverified figures are marked in red. Microsoft's EPS ($4.92 vs. a separately reported $4.89 adjusted figure) and its FY2027 capex guide; Amazon's Q3 consensus (not verified this run); today's GDP and claims prints (not yet released at press time); VIX (source data internally inconsistent this run); Nikkei close timestamp; the newer Reuters/Ipsos approval

reading's fieldwork date; and this morning's IRGC claims (three tankers mined, a captured US drone, intermediary contact on reopening) — all single- or state-media-sourced, uncorroborated by UKMTO, CENTCOM or any flag state. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.